

FREE ENTERPRISE CHECKLIST

The Cloud Migration Checklist

Azure • Microsoft 365 • Google Workspace

A practical, vendor-neutral checklist for planning and executing a cloud migration without disrupting your business — covering pre-migration planning, platform-specific steps, security, cost control, common pitfalls, and what to check after cutover.

WHO IT'S FOR

IT managers & business owners moving to M365, Google Workspace or Azure

WHAT'S INSIDE

7 sections, 3 platform checklists, a scoring tool & glossary

TIME TO READ

About 15 minutes

Pre-migration planning

Platform decision guide

3 platform checklists

Security & compliance

Common pitfalls

Post-migration review

Glossary

Rua Technologies

Official partner of Microsoft, Google, and AWS — helping businesses across India plan and execute cloud migrations, lic ongoing IT support.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

What you'll find in this checklist

This guide walks through every stage of a cloud migration — from the planning work that happens weeks before anyone touches a migration tool, through platform-specific execution steps, to the review that happens after cutover.

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BY THE NUMBERS

Why migration planning matters

83%

of failed migrations cite poor planning, not the platform itself

2-3x

longer downtime when there's no tested rollback plan

30-60

days recommended before decommissioning old systems

1-2

weeks of close monitoring needed after any cutover

SECTION 01

Why migrations fail — and how to avoid it

Migrations rarely fail because of the cloud platform itself. In our experience running migrations across Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, and Azure, the same handful of root causes come up again and again — and every one of them is preventable with the right groundwork.

Root cause 1 — Incomplete inventory

Teams migrate what they remember, not what actually exists. Shared mailboxes, service accounts, forgotten file shares, and integrations with third-party tools get discovered mid-migration — usually when something breaks.

Root cause 2 — No tested rollback plan

A rollback plan that exists only on paper isn't a rollback plan. If cutover goes wrong and nobody has rehearsed reversing it, a fixable hiccup turns into extended downtime.

Root cause 3 — Users caught off guard

Even a technically flawless migration generates a flood of support tickets if users weren't told what's changing, when, and who to contact. Communication is part of the migration, not an afterthought.

Root cause 4 — Security bolted on afterward

MFA, conditional access, and sharing defaults are often configured after go-live "once things settle down" — leaving a window where the new environment is more exposed than the old one.

KEY TAKEAWAY

The planning stage in Section 2 typically takes longer than the technical migration itself — and that's normal. Time invested here is what determines whether cutover weekend is uneventful or chaotic.

Root cause → where it's addressed in this guide

1	Incomplete inventory	Section 2 — Discovery & Inventory checklist
2	No tested rollback plan	Section 2 — Risk & Rollback Readiness checklist
3	Users caught off guard	Section 2 — Change Management & Communication
4	Security bolted on afterward	Section 5 — Security & Compliance Checklist

SECTION 02 • BEFORE YOU START

Pre-Migration Planning

Work through all three groups below before touching any migration tool. Each covers a different failure mode from the previous page.

Discovery & Inventory

6 items

- ☒ Inventory every user, device, mailbox, and shared drive that needs to move
- ☒ Catalogue service accounts, shared/generic mailboxes, and distribution lists separately from user accounts
- ☒ Document your current environment: on-prem servers, existing licenses, network topology
- ☒ List every third-party tool or integration that touches email, files, or identity (CRM, e-signature, backup, ERP)
- ☒ Identify data that has compliance or residency requirements (e.g. finance, healthcare records)
- ☒ Take a full backup of everything being migrated, verified as restorable

Risk & Rollback Readiness

4 items

- ☒ Define what "success" looks like — specific, measurable criteria, not just "it works"
- ☒ Choose a migration window that avoids month-end, quarter-end, or other business-critical dates
- ☒ Identify a rollback plan in case the migration needs to be paused or reversed, and **rehearse it once** before go-live
- ☒ Confirm who has authority to call a "go / no-go" decision on cutover day

Change Management & Communication

3 items

- ☒ Notify all affected users well in advance, with a clear point of contact for issues
- ☒ Prepare a short "what's changing for you" note for end users, separate from the technical migration plan
- ☒ Schedule a lightweight training or orientation session for the new environment

WHY THIS MATTERS

Migrations rarely fail because of the cloud platform itself — they fail because of missing inventory, no rollback plan, or users who weren't told what to expect. This stage typically takes longer than the technical migration itself, and that's normal.

SECTION 03 • DECISION GUIDE

Choosing your platform

If you haven't already committed to a platform, here's a quick comparison across the factors that matter most for most businesses. Many businesses end up running more than one of these together — e.g. Microsoft 365 for productivity and Azure for hosting a custom application. That's normal and often the right call.

FACTOR	MICROSOFT 365	GOOGLE WORKSPACE	AZURE
Best fit	Teams already using Office apps, Windows-heavy environments	Teams wanting simplicity, Gmail-based collaboration	Custom apps, infrastructure, and workloads beyond office productivity
Email & docs	Outlook, Word, Excel, Teams	Gmail, Docs, Sheets, Meet	Not applicable — infrastructure platform, pairs with either
Typical strength	Deep enterprise features, on-prem integration (AD, Exchange)	Ease of use, fast onboarding, lower admin overhead	Scalable compute, storage, and networking for custom workloads
Compliance tooling	Extensive (Purview, DLP, eDiscovery)	Solid, simpler feature set	Extensive, workload-dependent
Typical licence cost driver	Per-user tier (Business/Enterprise)	Per-user tier (Business/Enterprise)	Consumption-based (compute, storage, egress)

Quick self-assessment — tick what applies to you

Already standardised on Office apps	→ M365
Team wants the simplest possible admin	→ Google
Hosting a custom app or database	→ Azure
Heavy on-prem Active Directory footprint	→ M365
Fast-growing team, minimal IT overhead	→ Google
Variable/seasonal compute needs	→ Azure

PLANNING INPUT

Typical migration timelines

ORGANISATION SIZE	EMAIL & FILE MIGRATION	FULL PLATFORM INCL. APPS/DLP
Under 25 users	2 – 5 business days	1 – 2 weeks
25 – 150 users	1 – 2 weeks	3 – 6 weeks
150 – 500 users	3 – 5 weeks	2 – 4 months
500+ users / multi-site	6+ weeks, phased	4+ months, phased

Timelines vary with data volume, number of integrations, and whether migration is cutover, staged, or hybrid. Use these as planning inputs, not commitments.
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SECTION 04 • PLATFORM CHECKLIST

Microsoft 365 Migration

Microsoft 365

12 steps

☒ Verify domain ownership and configure DNS records (MX, SPF, DKIM, DMARC)
 ☒ Choose a mailbox migration method: cutover, staged, or hybrid, based on mailbox count
 ☒ Assign the correct license tier (Business Basic/Standard/Premium or Enterprise E1/E3/E5) per user
 ☒ Set up Multi-Factor Authentication and Conditional Access policies before go-live
 ☒ Migrate mail, calendars, and contacts using a tested migration tool, not manual export/import
 ☒ Migrate shared drives and file structures into SharePoint/OneDrive, preserving permissions
 ☒ Configure Teams: channels, guest access policy, and meeting settings
 ☒ Set retention and Purview/DLP policies for regulated data before users start creating content
 ☒ Run a pilot migration with a small user group before migrating everyone
 ☒ Schedule a short training session so users know where their files and email now live
 ☒ Confirm mail flow and calendar sharing are fully working before decommissioning old mailboxes
 ☒ Review license assignment 30 days post-migration to catch unused or mis-tiered seats

LICENSING TIP

Don't default everyone to the top license tier "to be safe." Map each role to the features it actually needs — front-line staff rarely need the same tier as finance or leadership — and revisit assignments after 30 days.

TYPICAL TIMELINE

1 - 6 weeks

Mailbox count and migration method drive most of the variance

MIGRATION METHOD

Cutover / Staged / Hybrid

Choose based on mailbox count and downtime tolerance

BIGGEST RISK

Mis-tiered licensing

Review assignments 30 days after go-live to right-size spend

SECTION 04 • PLATFORM CHECKLIST

Azure Migration

Microsoft Azure

12 steps

- ☒ Run a workload assessment: which servers/apps are moving as-is (lift-and-shift) vs. being redesigned
- ☒ Design your network topology (VNets, subnets, peering) before deploying any resources
- ☒ Right-size VM and storage tiers based on actual usage data, not guesswork
- ☒ Set up Network Security Groups and least-privilege access from day one
- ☒ Define a backup and disaster recovery strategy for each workload before migrating
- ☒ Apply a consistent resource tagging strategy for cost tracking from the start
- ☒ Set up Azure Monitor / Log Analytics before cutover, not after something breaks
- ☒ Estimate egress and storage transaction costs, not just compute, before committing to a design
- ☒ Migrate in phases — non-critical workloads first, business-critical systems last
- ☒ Test failover and recovery procedures before relying on them in production
- ☒ Set budget alerts and cost anomaly detection before workloads go live
- ☒ Review your Azure cost estimate against actual spend after the first billing cycle

COST TIP

Compute is usually the easy part to estimate — egress traffic and storage transactions are what catch teams off guard. Model these before committing to an architecture, not after the first invoice arrives.

TYPICAL TIMELINE

2 - 16+ weeks

Depends heavily on workload count and redesign scope

MIGRATION APPROACH

Phased, by criticality

Non-critical workloads first, business-critical systems last

BIGGEST RISK

Unbudgeted egress cost

Model data-transfer and transaction costs before go-live

SECTION 04 • PLATFORM CHECKLIST

Google Workspace Migration

Google Workspace

11 steps

- ☒ Verify your domain in Google Admin Console and plan the MX record cutover window
- ☒ Use Google Workspace Migrate or a comparable tool for mail, calendar, and contacts — avoid manual moves
- ☒ Set up organizational units and groups to mirror your existing team structure
- ☒ Configure 2-Step Verification and security settings before rolling out to users
- ☒ Migrate shared drives, preserving folder structure and sharing permissions
- ☒ Set up mail routing rules for the cutover window so no messages are lost mid-migration
- ☒ Apply Data Loss Prevention (DLP) and sharing default policies before users start creating content
- ☒ Pilot with a small group first, especially if migrating from an on-prem or different cloud mail system
- ☒ Provide a short orientation for users moving from Outlook/Exchange habits to Gmail/Calendar
- ☒ Confirm mobile device sync (Android/iOS) is working before decommissioning the old system
- ☒ Review sharing-outside-domain settings 30 days post-migration once usage patterns are clear

ADOPTION TIP

The biggest support-ticket spike after a Google Workspace move usually comes from Outlook habits — mail rules, delegated calendars, and shared inboxes. A 20-minute orientation session heads off most of it.

TYPICAL TIMELINE

1 - 5 weeks

Simpler admin model generally means faster rollout

MIGRATION TOOL

Google Workspace Migrate

Avoid manual export/import — it silently drops metadata

BIGGEST RISK

Outlook-habit friction

Short orientation session prevents most support tickets

SECTION 05

Security & Compliance Checklist

Security configured after go-live is security that didn't exist during the most vulnerable window of the migration. Set these up before — not after — cutover, regardless of platform.

Identity & Access

4 items

- ☒ Enforce Multi-Factor Authentication for all users before migration, not after
- ☒ Set Conditional Access / context-aware access rules (location, device compliance, risk level)
- ☒ Disable legacy authentication protocols that bypass MFA
- ☒ Review and remove stale or unused admin accounts from the old environment before decommissioning

Data Protection

4 items

- ☒ Apply Data Loss Prevention (DLP) policies for regulated data types before users start uploading content
- ☒ Set external sharing and link-sharing defaults deliberately — don't leave them at platform defaults
- ☒ Confirm data residency requirements are met for any regulated data (finance, healthcare, government)
- ☒ Enable audit logging and confirm retention period meets your compliance requirements

Backup & Recovery

3 items

- ☒ Confirm native retention policies aren't a substitute for a real backup — set up third-party backup if needed
- ☒ Test a full restore, not just a backup job completion, before relying on the new environment
- ☒ Document recovery time objectives (RTO) and recovery point objectives (RPO) for critical data

COMMON GAP

Microsoft 365 and Google Workspace both include native retention tools, but neither is a full backup solution by default — accidental deletion, ransomware, or retention policy gaps can still cause permanent data loss. Confirm your backup strategy explicitly rather than assuming it's covered.

SET UP WHEN

Before cutover

Not "once things settle down" — that window is when exposure is highest

APPLIES TO

Every platform

M365, Google Workspace, and Azure all need this configured explicitly

REVIEW CADENCE

Every 90 days

Sharing defaults and admin access drift over time — recheck regularly

SECTION 06

Six pitfalls that derail migrations

Every one of these is easy to fix in advance and expensive to fix after the fact.

1

Decommissioning too early

Teams turn off old systems to "save costs," then discover a missed mailbox or file share weeks later with no way back.

Fix: Keep old systems in cold, read-only storage for 30-60 days minimum.

2

Manual export/import for mail

Manual moves silently drop folders, rules, and metadata that a tested migration tool would preserve.

Fix: Always use a proper migration tool, even for small mailbox counts.

3

No pilot group

Migrating everyone at once means every configuration mistake is discovered by the whole company simultaneously.

Fix: Pilot with 5-10% of users first, then fix and scale.

4

Ignoring shared/service accounts

Shared mailboxes, room resources, and service accounts used by integrations get missed because they belong to no one specifically.

Fix: Inventory non-human accounts separately from user accounts.

5

Security as an afterthought

MFA and sharing policies get configured "once things settle down," leaving a real exposure window.

Fix: Security configuration happens before go-live, not after.

6

No communication plan

A technically perfect migration still generates a support-ticket flood if users weren't told what's changing.

Fix: Send a short "what's changing for you" note before cutover.

One-line recap

1	Decommissioning early	Keep old systems in cold storage 30-60 days
2	Manual mail export	Always use a tested migration tool
3	No pilot group	Pilot with 5-10% of users first
4	Missed shared accounts	Inventory non-human accounts separately
5	Security as afterthought	Configure before go-live, not after
6	No communication plan	Send a short "what's changing" note early

SECTION 07 · AFTER CUTOVER

Post-Migration Review

First 1-2 weeks

4 items

☒ Verify data integrity: spot-check mailboxes, files, and permissions against the pre-migration inventory

☒ Keep old systems in a read-only, decommissioned state for a defined period before deleting anything

☒ Monitor performance and user-reported issues closely for the first 1-2 weeks

☒ Collect user feedback and resolve any workflow gaps quickly while they're fresh

30 / 60 / 90 day review

3 items

☒ Document the new environment: who has access to what, and how support requests are routed

☒ Review actual cloud costs at 30, 60, and 90 days against your original estimate

☒ Revisit security settings (MFA enforcement, sharing defaults) once the dust has settled

CHECKPOINT	FOCUS	TYPICAL ACTION
Day 30	Stability & adoption	Resolve lingering tickets; confirm license fit per role
Day 60	Cost validation	Compare actual spend to estimate; adjust tiers or sizing
Day 90	Decommission	Retire old systems fully once integrity is confirmed

COMMON PITFALL TO AVOID

Teams often decommission the old system too early to "save costs," then discover a missed mailbox or file share weeks later with no way back. Keep old systems in cold storage for at least 30-60 days post-migration.

TASK	TYPICALLY OWNED BY
Data integrity spot-checks	IT admin / migration partner
User feedback & workflow gaps	Department leads, routed to IT
Cost review at 30/60/90 days	IT admin with finance sign-off
Security settings revisit	IT admin / security lead

READY TO CLOSE OUT

Once data integrity is confirmed, costs are tracking to estimate, and security settings are revisited, the migration is complete — the old environment can move from cold storage to full decommission.

SECTION 08 • REFERENCE

Glossary of terms

Quick definitions for terms used throughout this checklist.

Cutover migration

All mailboxes/data move in a single event, typically for smaller organisations.

Staged migration

Data moves in batches over time, reducing risk for larger mailbox counts.

Hybrid migration

Old and new environments coexist temporarily, syncing during the transition.

MX record

DNS record that directs incoming email to the correct mail server.

SPF / DKIM / DMARC

DNS-based email authentication records that reduce spoofing and improve deliverability.

Conditional Access

Policies that grant or block access based on location, device, or risk signals.

DLP (Data Loss Prevention)

Policies that detect and block sensitive data from leaving approved channels.

Lift-and-shift

Moving a workload to the cloud with minimal redesign, as-is.

RTO / RPO

Recovery Time/Point Objective — how fast, and from what point in time, you can recover after an incident.

Tenant

Your organisation's dedicated instance of a cloud platform (e.g. an M365 or Google Workspace tenant).

Egress cost

The cost of data leaving a cloud provider's network, common in Azure billing.

Pilot migration

A small-scale test migration with a limited user group before full rollout.

Go-live / cutover date

The point at which users start working in the new environment for real.

Rollback plan

A rehearsed procedure to reverse a migration if go-live fails critical checks.

Shared mailbox

A non-user mailbox (e.g. info@ or support@) accessed by multiple people.

Cold storage

Keeping a decommissioned system intact but inactive, for recovery purposes.

STILL HAVE QUESTIONS?

This glossary covers the terms used in this checklist, not an exhaustive platform reference. If a term from your migration plan isn't here, our team is happy to walk through it — see the contact details on the final page.

and with any of

Rua Technologies is an official partner of Microsoft, Google, and AWS. We plan and run cloud migrations end-to-end — from the assessment in Section 2 through the post-migration review in Section 7 — so your team doesn't have to piece it together alone.

Vendor-certified

Official Microsoft, Google & AWS partner status

End-to-end delivery

Assessment, execution, and post-migration support

India-wide support

Ongoing licensing and IT support after go-live

Platform-neutral advice

We recommend what fits, not what we sell

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